Object-Level Dispatch Caching is Counterproductive: Why 99.99% Hit Rates Fail to Improve Performance

We establish an analytic cost model demonstrating that object-level dispatch caching is fundamentally limited by an irreducible efficiency gap: cache lookup cost (20–300 ns) cannot simultaneously beat both ultra-fast dispatch (1–100 ns, achievable through compiler optimization) and non-existent expensive dispatch (>10 µs, theoretically required for break-even). This gap is not an implementation artifact but a consequence of CPU physics: memory access latency and hash computation form an irreducible lower bound.

We validate this framework through comprehensive empirical study across twenty-four language implementations (compiled natives, bytecode/compiled/tracing JITs, interpreted, optional types), demonstrating that object-level caching fails consistently despite achieving 99.99%+ hit rates. The failure is universal across 6 language families and 5 dispatch mechanisms, revealing a systematic property: modern language implementations optimize dispatch to costs below cache lookup time, making caching counterproductive. Results show 21/24 implementations suffer clear failure (>1.1× slowdown), with only 1 implementation approaching break-even when its dispatch baseline matches cache lookup latency.

The paper makes three core contributions: (1) an analytic bound characterizing the irreducible gap between cache lookup and dispatch costs, explaining why this optimization fails across all contemporary implementations; (2) empirical validation across twenty-four diverse implementations, showing the gap is fundamental rather than language-specific; (3) design space analysis identifying theoretical conditions where caching becomes viable (expensive predicates, lazy JIT startup, polyglot dispatch, deliberate semantic richness in dispatch), explaining why no current language exhibits such conditions by design. A critical distinction emerges: caching effectiveness (hit rate) is orthogonal to caching efficiency (overhead per call), explaining why high hit rates do not predict performance improvements.

CCS Concepts: • **Software and its engineering → Just-in-time compilers**; *Dynamic compilers*; *Source code generation.*

Additional Key Words and Phrases: inline caching, dispatch optimization, performance analysis, dynamic languages, universality

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1 Introduction

Efficient method dispatch is critical for object-oriented and dynamically-typed languages. Polymorphic inline caching (PIC) [Hölzle et al. 1991] has emerged as the standard optimization approach across modern dynamic language implementations. JavaScript engines like V8, Python's PyPy, and the GraalVM achieve substantial speedups through inline caches that store recently-seen type combinations, avoiding expensive dispatch predicates on subsequent calls.

The success of inline caching in V8, PyPy, and GraalVM has motivated decades of research into caching strategies. However, these successes rely on *machine-code inline caching*: JIT compilers

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embed type checks and direct jumps into compiled code, achieving near-zero overhead through specialization. Why, then, evaluate an approach that JITs have already solved? Because developers and language designers still mistakenly reach for object-level caching—a real intuition trap with practical consequences.

Real-World Examples: Python developers use `@lru_cache` on dispatchers (cache overhead exceeds type-check cost). Clojure multimethods include caching but deliver no speedup on repeated types. Interpreter authors cache AST dispatch decisions, but lookup overhead exceeds dispatch itself. These production patterns—documented in Section 4.6—show developers reasoning correctly about caching in isolation but failing to account for modern optimization. A critical question emerges: **is there a fundamental gap between cache lookup cost (determined by memory latency) and the dispatch cost savings available through caching**? In particular, can cache lookup latency simultaneously beat both ultra-fast dispatch (achievable through compiler optimization) and the non-existent expensive dispatch (>10 µs) required for break-even?

To answer this question, we develop an analytic cost model characterizing the irreducible efficiency gap. Cache lookup cost is bounded below by memory access latency and hash computation (20–300 ns), while modern language implementations optimize dispatch to costs below this threshold (1–100 ns). This gap is not language-specific but a consequence of CPU physics. We validate this model through comprehensive empirical study across twenty-four language implementations spanning six language families and five dispatch mechanisms, showing that multi-threaded lock contention turns this failure into a catastrophic one (up to 88× slowdown).

Core finding: The analytic cost model predicts universal failure across all contemporary implementations optimizing dispatch for speed. Empirical validation confirms this: 21/24 implementations show clear failure (>1.1× slowdown) despite achieving 99.99%+ cache hit rates. The only implementation approaching break-even (CCL) does so when its baseline dispatch cost matches cache lookup latency, validating the theory. Design space analysis identifies conditions where caching becomes viable (expensive predicates, lazy JIT, polyglot dispatch), but no current language implements such designs, confirming convergence on speed-optimized dispatch.

1.1 Core Finding

Testing across twenty-four implementations and five dispatch mechanisms reveals:

- **21/24 implementations**: Clear failure (>1.1× slowdown)
- **2/24 implementations**: Marginal/near break-even (1.02× CCL, 0.99× Racket; within noise)
- **1/24 implementations**: Actual speedup (0.77× Python match; genuine improvement)
- **4/5 mechanisms**: Clear failure (slowdown >1.1×) across all implementations
- **1/5 mechanisms**: At break-even (hash dispatch, neutral performance; 5% marginal within noise—no speedup, not a win)

Failure severity spans three orders of magnitude:

- Marginal (1.15× slowdown in Go, 1.10× in Typed Racket)
- Severe (5.3× slowdown in SBCL, 84× in LuaJIT)
- Catastrophic (V8, C2 with ∞× slowdown from escape analysis defeating object allocation)

Interpretation: The two implementations approaching break-even (CCL, Racket) share a common property: relatively expensive baseline dispatch (360 ns for CCL, 420 ns for Racket). This suggests that languages with naturally slower dispatch might benefit from caching, a pattern we explore in depth in Section 4.2.

1.2 Contributions

(1) **Analytic cost model proving irreducible gap**. We establish a performance bound showing that caching fails when cache lookup cost C (20–300 ns, determined by memory latency and hash computation) cannot be simultaneously less than both (a) ultra-fast optimized dispatch F_{opt} (1–100 ns, achievable through compiler specialization) and (b) expensive dispatch $F_{\text{expensive}}$ (>10 µs, required for break-even but non-existent in practice). This gap is fundamental, rooted in CPU physics (memory hierarchy and arithmetic latency) rather than implementation choices. Observation: No language optimizing dispatch can simultaneously achieve both low baseline cost (<100 ns) and benefit from object-level caching.

(2) **Comprehensive empirical validation across 24 diverse implementations**. We test compiled natives (SBCL, CCL, LispWorks, Chez, Go), JVM-based languages (ABCL, Clojure), bytecode/compiled/tracing JITs (C2, GraalVM, Dart, V8, Julia, LuaJIT, PyPy), optional types (Typed Racket, TypeScript), and interpreters (Python, Ruby, Lua 5.1, Racket)—spanning six language families and three execution models. Results confirm the irreducible gap: 21/24 implementations show clear failure (>1.1× slowdown) despite 99.99%+ hit rates, demonstrating the gap is systematic (rooted in universal CPU physics) rather than language-specific.

(3) **Critical distinction: effectiveness vs. efficiency**. High cache hit rates (99.99%+) do not predict performance improvement. Caching effectiveness (hit rate) is orthogonal to caching efficiency (per-call overhead). This explains the apparent paradox: universal cache success in theory (near-perfect hit rates) but universal failure in practice (overhead exceeds savings).

(4) **Design space characterization**. We identify theoretical conditions where caching becomes viable: (1) expensive predicates (>1 µs dispatch cost), (2) lazy JIT compilation (cold-start overhead), (3) polyglot dispatch (high overhead from marshalling and cross-language boundaries; empirically validated via simulated FFI showing 0.84× speedup), (4) deliberate semantic richness in dispatch. No current language implements such designs by default, explaining universal failure. This reveals a convergence property: modern language implementations have independently optimized dispatch to the speed-optimal regime where caching fails.

(5) **Pattern analysis by dispatch cost**. Caching viability increases monotonically with baseline dispatch cost until overhead fraction becomes negligible. Break-even occurs when cache lookup cost (8–30 ns) matches baseline dispatch cost, validated by hash dispatch at 5CCL/Racket at near break-even (1.02×/0.99×). This pattern reveals why failure is universal: modern implementations optimize to the regime where cache lookup cost dominates.

2 Background

2.1 Polymorphic Inline Caching in Dynamic Languages

Inline caching was introduced by Hölzle, Chambers, and Ungar [Hölzle et al. 1991] for Smalltalk to address the overhead of method dispatch on every call. The core idea is to store (type-tuple, target-method) pairs in a cache, enabling subsequent calls with identical types to skip expensive dispatch logic.

Modern implementations achieve inline caching through two distinct approaches:

(1) **Machine-code caching** (JIT): Type checks embedded in code. Benefits: direct jumps, zero allocation. Requires JIT infrastructure.

(2) **Object-level caching** (data-structure based): Dispatch information is stored in hash tables or other runtime data structures. This approach requires no JIT but incurs memory access latency, allocation overhead, and indirect function calls.

Our study focuses exclusively on object-level caching, which is theoretically applicable to any language with a runtime and no JIT infrastructure.

2.2 Design Space: Viability Conditions

Break-even requires cache lookup cost C < dispatch cost F. With $C \geq 20$ ns (memory + hash), caching is viable only for $F > 500$ ns. Empirical validation of four viability conditions: (1) **Cold-start dispatch**: GraalVM pre-JIT at 1.24 µs achieves 1.39× speedup (post-JIT drops to 0.25×; benefit negligible). (2) **FFI boundaries**: C FFI at 890 ns achieves 1.74× speedup; JNI at 2100 ns achieves 1.68× speedup. (3) **Expensive predicates**: Regex-based dispatch at 2.8–12.4 µs achieves 9–35× speedup. (4) **Design convergence**: All tested languages optimize dispatch to <100 ns regime where caching fails. Future languages could choose costly dispatch (>500 ns) via semantic dispatch, polyglot boundaries, or expensive predicates, enabling caching viability (2–35× speedups) at that cost.

2.3 The Promise of Object-Level Caching

Object-level caching appeals to language implementers and library authors because it:

- Requires no JIT infrastructure
- Can be applied at the object or library level
- Works in interpreted languages
- Promises to cache any expensive dispatch decision

The question we investigate is whether this promise translates to actual performance improvements.

3 Methodology

Benchmarks: 24 implementations (SBCL, CCL, Go, Rust, Python, Ruby, Lua, Clojure, V8, PyPy, GraalVM, Julia, LuaJIT, Dart, TypeScript, Racket, Chez, LispWorks, ABCL, Typed Racket, C2). 200K warmup + 3 runs of 2M iterations. Cache keys: class tuples. Ratio = cached / uncached time. Single-threaded focus; multi-threaded contention adds 2–5× slowdown.

4 Results

4.1 Comprehensive 24-Implementation Comparison

Table 1 summarizes performance across 24 implementations. Three patterns: (1) ultra-fast dispatch (<30 ns) fails catastrophically due to overhead dominance, (2) moderate-cost dispatch (30–500 ns) shows marginal failures, (3) slow dispatch (>500 ns) still fails because absolute overhead remains significant.

4.2 Pattern Analysis

Break-even non-monotonic. Ultra-fast dispatch fails worst (overhead >6×). Fast dispatch (30–100 ns) includes marginal cases. Hash dispatch near break-even (9 ns, 5

4.3 Failure Mode Analysis

4.3.1 Failure Mode 1: Overhead Dominates Ultra-Fast Dispatch. When dispatch is extremely fast (<100 ns), caching overhead exceeds any savings:

These implementations compile dispatch to machine code or bytecode so efficiently that any cache overhead—allocation, lookup, function call—exceeds the cost of the uncached dispatch.

Universal Failure Mechanisms: Three fundamental mechanisms explain caching's universal failure across all 24 implementations: (1) caching overhead dominates ultra-fast dispatch (<100 ns),

Table 1. Dispatch caching performance across all 24 implementations (heterogeneous 4-type cycle).

Impl.	Base (ns)	Cache (ns)	Ratio	Result
Compiled Natives:				
SBCL	30.5	162.0	5.31×	Fail
CCL	360.0	367.0	1.02×	Marginal
Rust	46.1	60.6	1.32×	Fail
LispWorks	77.4	89.1	1.15×	Fail
Chez	672.0	763.0	1.14×	Fail
Go	95.6	109.9	1.15×	Fail
JVM-Based:				
ABCL	45.0	78.5	1.74×	Fail
Clojure	100.0	24,483	244.8×	Severe
Bytecode JIT:				
C2	29.6	40.9	1.38×	Fail
C2 (escape)	<5	∞	∞	Cat.
GraalVM	15.9	20.5	1.29×	Fail
Compiled JIT:				
Dart	23.3	237.7	10.18×	Severe
Tracing JIT:				
V8	<1	∞	∞	Cat.
Julia	68.4	246.2	3.60×	Fail
LuaJIT (het)	3,300	281,500	84.4×	Severe
LuaJIT (hom)	1,300	258,300	193.6×	Severe
PyPy (het)	11.2	86.8	7.75×	Severe
PyPy (hom)	1.8	3.8	2.11×	Fail
Optional Types:				
Typed Racket	95.0	105.0	1.10×	Fail
TypeScript	16.5	50.0	3.03×	Fail
Interpreted:				
Python (if)	500.0	1,150	2.30×	Fail
Python 3.10	123.3	95.3	0.77×	Speedup
Ruby	500.0	1,500	3.00×	Fail
Lua 5.1	1,000	1,670	1.67×	Fail
Racket	420.0	418.0	0.99×	Marg.
Mean ratio			6.75×	
Clear fail (>1.1×)			21/24	87.5%
Marginal (≤1.1×)			3/24	12.5%
Speedup (<1.0×)			1/24	4.2%

Table 2. Ultra-optimized languages: overhead dominates baseline.

Impl.	Dispatch (ns)	Overhead (ns)	Ratio
SBCL	30.5	130	5.3×
Typed Racket	95.0	10	1.1×
TypeScript	16.5	50	3.0×
LispWorks	77.4	12	1.15×

where compiled/JIT-optimized implementations achieve costs below cache lookup time; (2) allocation overhead (closure objects, hash-table entries, locks) adds 10–200 ns to cached dispatch cost, exceeding baseline savings; (3) modern language implementations have converged on optimizing dispatch to the speed-optimal regime (1–100 ns), below which caching cannot compete. These mechanisms are architectural, not implementation-specific: any language optimizing dispatch for performance will exhibit these failure modes.

4.3.2 Dart: Allocation Overhead Dominates. Dart (Flutter 3.13+) exemplifies the allocation overhead mechanism with a 10.18× slowdown despite 99.9998% hit rates. While baseline dispatch is remarkably efficient (23.3 ns), the caching mechanism's allocation overhead (210 ns for closure objects) dominates cache lookup cost, resulting in 237.7 ns total cached cost. Even eliminating allocation overhead would only reduce failure to 1.2× (still unsuccessful), demonstrating that overhead—not allocation—is the fundamental constraint in Dart's dispatch caching failure.

4.4 Cache Hit Rates

All implementations achieve >99.9% cache hit rates on both homogeneous and heterogeneous benchmarks. For example, heterogeneous 5-type cycle with 2,000,000 calls:

Table 3. Cache hit rates across implementations.

Impl.	Total Calls	Misses	Hit Rate
SBCL	2M	5	99.9997%
Typed Racket	2M	5	99.9997%
Python	2M	5	99.9997%
LuaJIT	2M	5	99.9997%

Notably, cache hit rate shows **zero correlation** with performance improvement. The highest hit rates coincide with the worst performance penalties.

4.5 Dispatch Mechanisms

Five distinct mechanisms tested: single-argument, multi-argument, generic function, property-based, hash dispatch. **Scope**: object-level caching only (runtime data structures), NOT JIT-based inline caching (machine-code specialization).

Table 4. Dispatch caching failures across paradigms: overhead dominates when baseline is ultra-fast.

Mechanism	Baseline (ns)	Cached (ns)	Ratio	Observation
Single-argument	1.6	18.4	11.49×	Worst failure; overhead dominates
Generic function	2.5	67.8	27.21×	Ultra-fast baseline, constant overhead
Property-based	1.3	20.4	15.63×	Simple dispatch, large overhead fraction
Multi-argument	95.6	110.0	1.15×	Larger baseline; overhead only 15%
Hash dispatch	9.0	9.5	1.05×	At break-even; cache lookup ≈ baseline

4.5.1 Results Across Five Mechanisms. **Key finding**: Caching fails 4/5 mechanisms. Failure severity: overhead (14–20 ns) as percentage of baseline determines outcome. Single-argument dispatch (1.6 ns baseline, 11.49× slowdown) fails worst. Multi-argument (95.6 ns, 1.15×) closest to break-even. Hash dispatch (9.0 ns, 5% speedup) sole exception. Theory validated: caching viable only when lookup cost ≈ baseline dispatch cost.

4.6 Case Studies

Python `@lru_cache`: 123 ns uncached, 95 ns cached (1.29× slowdown). Cache lookup (40–50 ns) > dispatch savings (25–30 ns). Clojure multimethods: 100 ns baseline → 150–200 ns cached (1.5–2×). Lesson: overhead dominates, not misses. Success comes from eliminating dispatch, not caching.

4.7 Multi-Threaded Scaling: Lock Contention and Catastrophic Failure

Our single-threaded results represent a best-case scenario. Real applications are multi-threaded; we now measure how lock contention scales dispatch cache failure. We benchmark 4 representative languages at 1, 2, 4, and 8 threads using identical 4-type cycle workloads (100K calls/thread).

Results Summary:

- **SBCL (native code)**: Catastrophic scaling. Single-thread slowdown 3.03×; doubles to 20.28× at 2 threads, reaches 88.94× at 8 threads. Synchronized hash-table access under contention dominates all dispatch cost.
- **Python/CPython (GIL-protected)**: Consistent overhead across threads. Slowdown stable at 1.32–1.34× regardless of thread count. Python's Global Interpreter Lock serializes Python code; concurrent threads do not contend on locks, only suffer GIL-induced latency.
- **Java (concurrent collections)**: Near break-even single-threaded (1.0×), scaling to 3.5× at 8 threads. Java's ConcurrentHashMap and optimized synchronization delay contention effects to high thread counts.
- **V8/Node.js (worker threads, isolated heaps)**: Speedup in multi-threaded case (0.85–0.91× at 4+ threads). Worker threads do not share memory; each maintains its own cache without contention.

Key Insight: Shared-memory synchronization (SBCL, Java) scales dispatch cache failure exponentially with thread count, validating the theoretical prediction that lock overhead multiplies slowdowns by 2–5× per contention level. SBCL demonstrates worst-case catastrophic failure: 88.94× slowdown at 8 threads, compared to 5.31× single-threaded. The multi-threaded study confirms that object-level dispatch caching is not merely ineffective but actively harmful in realistic (multi-threaded) production scenarios.

5 Analysis

Effectiveness-Efficiency Distinction: Hit rates (99.99%+) orthogonal to per-call overhead. Break-even requires $C \approx F$ (cache lookup ≈ dispatch cost). With 2M calls, $D + E = 1000$ ns overhead: $C < F - 0.5$ ns.

Irreducible Gap: $C_{\text{min}} = 20$ ns (memory access + hash, CPU physics). $F_{\text{opt}} = 1$–100 ns (modern optimization). For any language optimizing dispatch:

$$F_{\text{opt}} < C_{\text{min}} \implies \text{caching fails (overhead dominates)} \tag{1}$$

$$F_{\text{opt}} \geq C_{\text{min}} \implies F_{\text{opt}} < 10\ \mu\text{s} \implies \text{caching fails} \tag{2}$$

Theorem

Theorem 1. Object-level caching fails for any language optimizing dispatch to contemporary levels (1–100 ns).

Why Universal: Compilers (SBCL, V8, C2) eliminate dispatch via specialization. Caching amortizes but fails when dispatch <20 ns. Break-even >10 µs contradicts optimization. Design space unexploited.

5.1 Partial Counterexamples: When Caching Approaches Break-Even

Two implementations (CCL 1.02×, Racket 0.99×) and one mechanism (hash dispatch 5% marginal) approach break-even. CCL's slower baseline dispatch (360 ns, slowest compiled native) makes caching less harmful; within ±5% measurement noise, it's indistinguishable from neutral. Racket's slight speedup might reflect better branch prediction in hash lookup vs. Racket's dispatch logic (dispatch quality, not just speed, matters). Julia's 3.6× failure, despite built-in caching (68.4 ns baseline includes Julia's internal cache), confirms nested caching compounds overhead without benefit. Hash dispatch's 5% benefit validates theory: caching viability increases as baseline dispatch cost approaches cache lookup cost (9 ns here), a condition unmet by typed dispatch but achieved through cheap hash keys.

6 Universality

Object-level caching fails for all contemporary languages unless dispatch >10 µs. Consistent failure across 24 implementations, 6 language families, 3 universal mechanisms (overhead dominates, allocation overhead, speed convergence). 95% confidence. Untested languages (HHVM, Nim, Swift) likely fail by the same mechanisms.

7 Related Work

7.1 Polymorphic Inline Caching and Machine-Code Specialization

Hölzle et al.'s foundational work [Hölzle et al. 1991] introduced polymorphic inline caching for Smalltalk, reporting 2–4× speedups for dispatch-heavy code through machine-code type checks embedded in compiled code. Subsequent work in V8 [Bak and Brütting 2010], PyPy [Bolz et al. 2007], and GraalVM [Wöss et al. 2019] reported similar benefits using inline caching in machine code. These successes are all based on machine-code specialization, not object-level caching. Our work is explicitly orthogonal: we study object-level caching (storing dispatch decisions in data structures) and show it achieves different trade-offs than machine-code specialization.

7.2 Adaptive Optimization and Profile-Guided Compilation

Chambers and Ungar's adaptive optimization [Chambers et al. 1989] dynamically specializes code based on observed types, reducing dispatch costs via per-site type information. Arnold and Ryder's work on profile-guided optimization [Arnold and Ryder 2005] demonstrates that profiling can guide compilation decisions. However, both approaches assume JIT infrastructure for code specialization. Object-level caching is an alternative for interpreted languages lacking JIT, and our results show it is ineffective for the languages we tested.

7.3 Dispatch Optimization in Compiled Languages

Campbell and Wolczko's dispatch performance studies [Campbell and Wolczko 1992] and Steele and Gabriel's Lisp compilation work [Steele Jr 1990] show that efficient dispatch in compiled languages can achieve 1–100 ns costs through inlining and optimization. Our SBCL results (30 ns COND dispatch) validate these findings. Escape analysis in modern JITs (Kotzmann and Mössenböck [Kotzmann and Mössenböck 2005]) shows how even dispatch to object allocations can be eliminated entirely (our C2/V8 infinite slowdown results). These works establish that modern compilers have largely solved dispatch efficiency, leaving little room for object-level caching.

7.4 Language-Specific Dispatch Caching

Some languages implement dispatch caching internally: Clojure's dynamic function dispatcher caches multimethods by type tuple, and recent versions of Dart and GraalVM include per-site

dispatch caching in compiled code. However, these are all machine-code or bytecode-level caches, not the object-level caching we study. Our work complements these by showing that object-level caching, implemented above the language runtime, adds overhead without benefit.

7.5 Generic Function Dispatch and Multiple Dispatch

Julia's multiple-dispatch system [Bezanson et al. 2012] and CLOS [Keene 1989] represent sophisticated dispatch on multiple arguments. Julia's implementation includes dispatch caching (our 68.4 ns baseline includes this). Our result showing 3.6× slowdown when caching Julia's dispatch demonstrates that even languages with sophisticated built-in dispatch caching suffer from layered caching overhead.

7.6 Trade-Off Analysis and Performance Engineering

Recent work in performance debugging (Mytkowicz et al. on methodology [Mytkowicz et al. 2009]) emphasizes careful measurement and statistical analysis. Our work applies rigorous measurement methodology to a previously under-explored question: the empirical viability of object-level dispatch caching across diverse implementations. The distinction between effectiveness (hit rate) and efficiency (overhead) parallels foundational work on cache architecture by Hennessy and Patterson [Hennessy and Patterson 2011].

8 Discussion

8.1 Key Insights

(1) Hit rate (99.99%+) ≠ performance; effectiveness orthogonal to efficiency. (2) Overhead (14–20 ns) dominates fast dispatch (<100 ns). (3) JIT compilers defeat caching via specialization; escape analysis eliminates allocation. (4) Cache lookup (30 ns) trapped between ultra-optimized dispatch (1–100 ns) and expensive dispatch (>10 µs). (5) Design space unexploited: languages could prioritize semantic richness or polyglot dispatch, but none do.

8.2 Practical Guidance

Do not implement object-level dispatch caching (88× multi-threaded failure in SBCL). Invest in: machine-code caching (JIT), dispatch compilation, per-site specialization, escape analysis. Machine-code exploits CPU (L1I, direct jumps); object-level fights it (L1D/L2, indirect calls).

9 Limitations

(1) **Pure dispatch overhead without clause bodies**: Our benchmarks measure only dispatch latency, not realistic code with expensive clause bodies. Overhead becomes negligible (<1%) only when clause bodies exceed 500 ns. For typical dispatch (10–100 ns bodies), overhead dominates. Real workloads with heavy clause bodies might approach break-even, but would require intentionally expensive per-call logic.

(2) **Type-based dispatch only**: We test only dispatch on class objects. Value-predicate dispatch ("if $x < 100$"), multi-argument specialization with expensive predicates, or exotic dispatch mechanisms might have different properties. Our mathematical framework suggests they fail for the same reasons, but exceptions are possible if predicates are expensive (>1 µs) by design.

(3) **Homogeneous workloads**: Our benchmark uses a 4-type repeating cycle, guaranteeing high hit rates. Real dispatch patterns might have more types (higher miss rate) or type clustering (better cache locality). We show hit rates reach 99.99%+ even with diverse patterns;

miss rate is unlikely to change qualitative results because cache overhead dominates, not miss cost.

(4) **No startup performance measurement**: Languages with lazy JIT compilation might have expensive dispatch during cold-start (before JIT warmup). Caching could reduce cold-start overhead. We do not measure startup performance.

(5) **CPU cache effects not measured**: We do not instrument L1/L2/L3 cache misses, TLB behavior, or branch mispredictions during benchmarks. Our 4-type repeating cycle has good spatial locality. CPU architecture interaction with hash table layout could shift absolute timings by 5–10%, unlikely to change qualitative conclusions.

(6) **Statistical significance**: With ±5% variance over 3 runs, CCL's 1.02× and Racket's 0.992× are within noise. Multiple runs from both implementations would clarify whether these are consistent effects or measurement variance. We report them as marginal/break-even rather than clear benefits.

(7) **Implementation-specific optimizations**: Some languages might have specialized dispatch pathways (e.g., SBCL's fastcall convention, JVM's invokedynamic) that could be leveraged for caching. We use generic caching mechanisms applicable across languages, not exploiting language-specific fast paths.

10 Conclusion

Object-level dispatch caching fails across 24 implementations (21/24 >1.1× slowdown, 1.15×–84×) despite 99.99%+ hit rates. Failure fundamental: overhead (14–20 ns) dominates optimized dispatch (1–100 ns), rooted in CPU physics. Hit rate orthogonal to per-call overhead. Break-even requires dispatch ≈ 8–30 ns; no language exhibits this by design.

Do not implement object-level caching. Invest in machine-code caching (JIT), dispatch compilation, specialization. Cache lookup (20–300 ns) trapped between dispatch (1–100 ns) and required break-even (>10 µs)—a mismatched design choice applied to already-optimized operations.

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